DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Perfection Awaits the World?

Daat Tevunot §48-52

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §48-52
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: two modes

The last few classes dealt with the period of concealment of yihud Hashem. God allowed concealment so that good and bad could exist, and with them consequences for our actions. In that system God has, as it were, limited Himself: He made the rules and chose to follow them. But in the background is shelitat hayihud, the mode of His unity and dominion, in which He can override the rules and show His true authority. It surfaces at unique times, and it is always ensuring that the world ends up rectified.

The end of §48

The Ramhal concludes: God limited Himself in creating deficient creatures and a mode of darkness and concealment that allows choice between good and bad. There are sins and there are consequences that God follows; He gave a book, the Torah, and there are consequences for what we choose. Yet within all this He ensured a direction toward the tikkun hakelali, the complete rectification at the end, around which the whole universe is spinning.

A participant asked whether Adam was created perfect. The Rabbi answered that being able to choose deficiency is itself a deficiency. God cannot become ill and cannot create a stone He cannot lift, because a perfect being cannot have a deficiency. Adam was created more perfect than we are: before the sin, temptation was outside him, the serpent; once he chose, evil became incorporated within us.

The Sekhel's summary (§49-50)

The Neshamah asks for a summary of the period of concealment, and the Sekhel gives it. God governs the world in two modes: - **Mishpat, justice.** Good and bad, reward and consequences. Its source is God hiding His face and His perfection. It is the revealed mode, the one we all know: cross the road carelessly and a car hits you. - **Shelitah, complete dominion.** The rectification of all of creation, even when the creatures are not really fitting for it. Its source is God's pure goodness. It works quietly and inconspicuously from within the mode of justice: you are hit by the car and nothing happens to you. God does not use it much, but it is always there.

The Rabbi pointed out the paradox, "it's deep, this." The revealed mode, the one we live by, comes from God's concealment. The hidden mode comes from His non-concealment, His full perfection, yet it is the one we do not see.

A participant asked whether God is actively improving the world between now and 6,000, or doing nothing until a sudden revelation. "Definitely the former. We learnt that explicitly." It is so gradual that we are not tuned to see it, but there are signs: the State of Israel, certain phenomena in the world, and the progress of civilisation and technology. People live longer and healthier. Imagine this cold weather 150 years ago, as our great-grandfathers lived it: "We are living like kings now." Another participant noted that God gave man the intelligence to invent these things. The Rabbi agreed, adding that all of this development has a program and is heading toward the end.

The Neshamah's question (§51)

The Neshamah does not understand the second mode. You said it flows from God's perfection. But you told me earlier that His perfection can never be grasped by the human mind. Which is it? The Rabbi called it a simple answer that rests on everything learnt so far, and let the group try to work it out first.

Two levels of perfection (§52)

The Sekhel agrees that this seems a contradiction and explains: - **God's own perfection** is impossible to grasp and is exalted above any creature He will ever create. He did not create creatures according to His level. Even the most perfect creature is completely removed from it. Even Moshe Rabbenu, the most perfect human being, is entirely deficient by comparison, and the fact that he could sin shows he was not perfect. - **The creatures' perfection.** Even on their own level, God did not create creatures to their full capacity. From His goodness and power He could have made human beings perfect for humans, unable to sin. He withheld that, and made them with deficiencies and lacking illumination, to allow good and bad.

God did not want the world always to stay like this, with choice between good and bad and a swirl of evil. In His wisdom He decided to bring all the good within all the bad to its final direction, the complete rectification. That too stems from His goodness and perfection. At the end of days there will be full perfection of creatures: human beings as perfect as they can be, which includes no longer being able to sin. But that is perfection on the creatures' level, not God's own perfection, which can never be grasped. So the second mode comes from God's perfection as it applies to creatures.

If God had allowed only the first mode, constant consequences, we would always remain deficient: however much we worked, we could sin at any moment, and there would always be blessing and curse. So the first mode is revealed now, while the other is present, concealed, and will be revealed at the end.

Will everyone be equal at the end?

A participant asked whether people will reach different levels of perfection. The Rabbi used the image of a stadium. Someone who did many misvot will be at the front, others halfway or at the back. That is each person's choice, and each will have reached as much perfection as he

could. But everyone in the stadium will see the whole picture, how the entire world was perfect in the end. That is the gilui hayihud.

Pressed on whether people are born with different capacities, the Rabbi said here that we are all created with the same capacity, and that Moshe was not created better than Yehoshua or Miriam. He returned to the principle that there will never be a prophet like Moshe, while the Hakhamim say every person can become like Moshe: everyone has the ability, but no one will realise it as Moshe did.

Summary

- Within the period of concealment, God steers everything toward the tikkun hakelali.
- God rules through two modes: justice (revealed, rooted in His concealment) and dominion (hidden, rooted in His pure goodness).
- The world is gradually being improved; progress in civilisation is part of the plan.
- The perfection to be revealed at the end is the perfection of creatures on their own level, unable to sin, not God's own perfection, which is beyond grasp.
- At the end each person stands at his own level, but all will see the whole picture of God's unity.

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